

The Birth Time Toolkit

Not knowing your birth time stops more people from booking a reading than anything else, and it shouldn't. Here is where the time is actually recorded, how to go and get it, and what a reading can still tell you if it turns out to be genuinely lost.

The whole of this guide is on this page, free, with nothing to fill in. If you would rather keep a copy — to work through at the records office, or to send to the parent who might remember — I'll email you the PDF.

Why two hours matters

Your Sun moves about one degree a day and takes roughly a month to cross a sign. That is why sun-sign astrology works as a mass-market product: everyone born in a three-week window shares one, and you can write a column for them.

Your rising sign — the degree of the zodiac coming over the eastern horizon at the moment you arrived — crosses the entire zodiac in twenty-four hours. A new sign rises roughly every two hours. One of those is a season. The other is a snapshot.

If it were only one more sign to talk about, an approximate time would be a small loss. It isn't, because the rising degree sets the whole house structure (molumen.com/explore/houses/) of the chart — the twelve areas of life it divides into. Move the rising degree and every planet migrates. A two-hour error doesn't change a detail; it relocates Saturn from your house of career to your house of partnership, and those are entirely different conversations.

Where the time is actually written down

Work down this list in order. Most people find it at the first or second step.

1. The long-form birth certificate

This is the one that usually works. The short form many people keep at home frequently omits the time; the long form, held by the vital records office of the state or country where you were born, usually includes it. In the United States it is a routine request. It is by far the most common way people find a time they thought was lost — and for most people it is a better use of the money than paying for rectification.

2. Hospital records

Some hospitals keep birth records for decades. Worth a call, and worth asking for medical records rather than the switchboard's first guess at who handles it.

3. Baby books and family papers

Time of birth is the sort of thing written down once, in the moment, and then filed. Baby books, family bibles, a parent's diary, a letter written that week, the back of a photograph.

4. Newspaper birth announcements

Local papers historically printed birth notices, sometimes with times. Library and newspaper archives have turned up times for people who had given up on finding one.

5. Family memory — held loosely

Ask, and treat the answer as a clue rather than a fact. "Just before dinner" narrows a twenty-four-hour window to a few hours, which is genuinely valuable. "Three o'clock" from a memory forty years old is often a rounded approximation, and rounding is exactly what causes the trouble.

Better questions than *what time was I born?*: Was it light or dark outside? Before or after a meal — which one? Had Dad already left for work, or come home? Was it the same day you went into labour? Did anyone miss anything because of it? People remember the shape of a day far better than they remember a number.



What to bring me, and how to say it

When you book, send the birth date, the birth city and country, and the time *with your confidence attached*. That last part is the one people leave off, and it is the one that changes how I read the chart.

- **From a document** — say so, and say which. This is the strongest case.
- **A range** — "between 2 and 4pm" is far more useful than a flat "3pm" that turns out to be a family rounding error.
- **A rough time of day** — "sometime in the morning" is real information and I can work with it.
- **Genuinely unknown** — say that too, plainly. It is not a problem.

If it is genuinely lost

You can have a real reading without a birth time. It will be a different reading, and I'll tell you which parts are missing.

What is lost: the rising sign, the entire house structure, and the Moon's exact degree — the Moon moves twelve to thirteen degrees a day, so across an unknown day it can shift meaningfully and occasionally change sign.

What is not: every planet's sign, in almost all cases. The aspects between them — the geometry of your chart, which is where a great deal of character actually lives. The condition of each planet by dignity (molumen.com/explore/dignities/). The current transits and which natal placements they are contacting.

That is most of a chart. A reading built on it is not a consolation prize. It answers *what are these patterns* very well and *where do they land* only in outline.

A word about rectification

Rectification is the technique of working backwards from known life events to estimate a birth time. It exists, it is a real discipline, and practitioners who specialise in it do careful work.

Two things worth knowing. It is substantial work, usually priced accordingly. And it produces an estimate rather than a fact — a well-reasoned hypothesis that fits the events you supplied, not a recovery of the true time. If someone offers you a rectified time with certainty, that confidence isn't warranted by the method.

The one thing to avoid

Don't guess and present the guess as exact. This is the genuinely bad outcome, and it is worse than knowing nothing.

An honest "I don't know" produces a good reading with stated limits. A confident wrong time produces a detailed, coherent, wholly inapplicable reading about the life of someone born two hours after you — and neither of us finds out until you are partway through wondering why none of it fits.

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Prepare for your reading

Everything else to bring, and what actually helps.

The Big Three

What the rising sign contributes once you have it.

If you don't know your time

The longer essay this guide was drawn from.



Found your time?

Bring it, and the real question you've been carrying. We'll look at your chart together.

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